

AMC PATHWAY

The Specialist pathway

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BEST FOR	Overseas-trained specialists seeking recognition by an Australian college
LEADS TO	Specialist registration
WHAT IS INVOLVED	College comparability assessment; exams or upskilling may apply

The Specialist pathway is for specialist international medical graduates (SIMGs), doctors with an overseas specialist qualification seeking specialist registration in Australia. The defining step is assessment by the relevant Australian specialist college, which decides how comparable your training and experience are to the Australian-trained specialist. If your qualification is on the Board's accepted list, check the faster Expedited Specialist pathway first.

Specialist recognition

The main route is specialist recognition. You apply to the AMC for primary source verification of your qualifications, then the relevant college assesses comparability and rates you as substantially comparable, partially comparable, or not comparable. Depending on the outcome you may take limited or provisional registration and complete a period of supervised practice and any college-required upskilling or exams, before applying for specialist registration. Each college sets its own process and fees.

Area of need

The area of need stream is for overseas-trained specialists filling a specialist-level position designated as an area of need. It's tied to a specific role, and is often combined with employer sponsorship.

Short-term training

There's also a short-term training in a medical specialty pathway, for specialists coming to Australia for a defined period of training or experience rather than long-term registration.

Is the expedited pathway faster for me?

For some specialties (general practice, anaesthesia, obstetrics and gynaecology, psychiatry, and from January 2026 general medicine and general paediatrics), eligible specialists can skip the comparability assessment entirely via the Expedited Specialist pathway. If your specific qualification is on the accepted list, that route is usually faster.

English, visas and registration

You must meet the English language requirement (see English requirements), and most roles are employer-sponsored, see visas. The pathway leads to specialist registration with the Medical Board. As an IMG you may also be affected by the Medicare moratorium, see Medicare.

Frequently asked questions

What does 'substantially comparable' mean?

It's the most favourable comparability rating, your training is judged closely comparable to the Australian-trained specialist, usually meaning a shorter period of supervised practice before specialist

registration.

Which college assesses me?

The Australian specialist college for your specialty (for example RACP, RACS, RACGP, ACEM or RANZCP). See the colleges directory.

Should I use the specialist or expedited pathway?

If your specific qualification is on the Board's accepted-qualifications list for an eligible specialty, the expedited pathway skips the comparability assessment and is usually faster. Otherwise, the standard specialist pathway applies.

Sources and last verified

1. Medical Board of Australia: Specialist pathway (verified 2026-06-15)
2. Medical Board of Australia: Specialist pathway, specialist recognition (verified 2026-06-15)
3. Australian Medical Council: Assessment pathways to registration (verified 2026-06-15)
4. Medical Board of Australia: Specialist pathway, area of need (verified 2026-06-15)
5. Medical Board of Australia: Short-term training in a medical specialty pathway (verified 2026-06-15)
6. Medical Board of Australia: Expedited Specialist pathway (verified 2026-06-15)
7. AHPRA: Expedited Specialist pathway now open to two new specialties (verified 2026-06-15)
8. Medical Board of Australia: English language skills registration standard (verified 2026-06-15)